Google Compute Engine Password Recovery

https://gemini.google.com/app/148c84646d872865

User prompt: google cloud engine get my password

Response: How you retrieve or set a password on a Google Compute Engine (GCE) instance depends on whether your Virtual Machine (VM) is running **Linux** or **Windows**.

Scenario 1: You are using a Linux VM

By default, **Linux VMs in Google Cloud do not use passwords**. Authentication is managed via SSH keys, `gcloud`, or Google Cloud's browser-based SSH terminal.

To gain root/admin access without a password:

You do not need a password to run commands with administrator privileges.

1. Connect to your VM via SSH (e.g., click the **SSH** button in the Cloud Console next to your VM instance).
2. Switch to the root user directly by running:

   ```
   sudo su
   ```

To set a password for your user or `root`:

If you need a password for a specific tool or local service:

1. SSH into the VM.
2. Run the `passwd` command to set a password for your current user:

   ```
   passwd
   ```

3. (Optional) To set or change the `root` password:

   ```
   sudo passwd root
   ```

Scenario 2: You are using a Windows VM

Windows VMs require a username and password to log in via Remote Desktop (RDP). Because Google Cloud does not store plain-text passwords, you must generate/reset one.

Method 1: Using the Google Cloud Console

1. Go to the **Compute Engine > VM instances** page in Google Cloud Console.
2. Click the name of your Windows VM instance.
3. At the top of the details page (or in the **Remote access** column), click **Set Windows password**.
4. Enter your username (or leave the default) and click **Set**.
5. Copy and save the generated password displayed on the screen.

Method 2: Using the `gcloud` CLI

Run the following command in your terminal or Cloud Shell:

```
gcloud compute reset-windows-password INSTANCE_NAME --zone=ZONE --user=USERNAME
```

(Replace `INSTANCE_NAME`, `ZONE`, and `USERNAME` with your instance's details.)

Scenario 3: Looking for your Google Cloud Account Password?

If you meant the password to sign in to your main Google Cloud account, Google does not display existing account passwords. You can reset it or manage stored browser credentials via the Google Password Manager.

Sources

1. Part-39: GCE VM Authentication in Google Cloud Platform
2. Manage accounts and credentials on Windows VMs | Compute Engine
3. Google Password Manager

User prompt: Google Cloud FileZilla

Response: To connect FileZilla to a Google Compute Engine (GCE) Linux instance, use **SFTP (SSH File Transfer Protocol)**. Because Google Cloud disables traditional FTP and standard password logins by default, authenticating requires an SSH key pair.

1 Generate an SSH Key Pair

Create the key on your local machine

Open your local terminal (macOS/Linux) or PowerShell (Windows) and generate an SSH key pair:

```
ssh-keygen -t rsa -f ~/.ssh/gcp_filezilla -C "your_username"
```

- Replace `your_username` with your desired username on the VM.
- Leave the passphrase blank (or enter one if you prefer extra security).

This creates two files in your `~/.ssh/` directory:

- `gcp_filezilla` (Private Key – used in FileZilla)
- `gcp_filezilla.pub` (Public Key – added to Google Cloud)

2 Add Public Key to Google Cloud

Register the key with your Compute Engine instance

1. Open your public key file (`gcp_filezilla.pub`) in a text editor and copy its full content.
2. In the Google Cloud Console, navigate to **Compute Engine > VM instances**.
3. Click on the name of your VM instance, then click **Edit** at the top.

4. Scroll down to **SSH Keys**, click **Add Item**, and paste the public key string.
5. Click **Save** at the bottom.

3 Add Private Key to FileZilla

Configure FileZilla's SSH authentication

1. Open **FileZilla**.
2. Go to **Edit > Settings** (macOS: **FileZilla > Settings**).
3. Under *Connection*, click **SFTP**.
4. Click **Add key file...** and select your private key file (`gcp_filezilla` or `gcp_filezilla.ppk`).
5. Click **OK** to save.

4 Connect via Site Manager

Save connection details in FileZilla

1. In FileZilla, go to **File > Site Manager** and click **New site**.
2. Configure the site settings:
   - **Protocol**: SFTP - SSH File Transfer Protocol
   - **Host**: Your VM's *External IP address*
   - **Port**: `22`
   - **Logon Type**: Interactive or Key file (select **Key file** if prompted, or **Normal** with your username and no password)
   - **User**: The same `your_username` used when generating the SSH key
3. Click **Connect**.

Key Things to Keep in Mind

- **Firewall Rules**: Ensure your GCP VPC firewall allows inbound traffic on TCP port 22 (SSH).
- **File Permissions**: When uploaded via SFTP, files will belong to `your_username`. If you need to edit system files (e.g., `/var/www/html`), you may need to adjust folder permissions via SSH (`sudo chown -R your_username:your_username /var/www/html`).

User prompt: Connect File Zilla to Google Cloud with SSH

Response: To connect FileZilla to your Google Cloud VM using SSH keys via SFTP, follow this step-by-step procedure.

1 Generate SSH Key Pair

Create authentication keys on your local computer

Open your local terminal (macOS/Linux) or PowerShell (Windows) and generate an SSH key pair:

```
ssh-keygen -t rsa -f ~/.ssh/gcp_filezilla -C "your_username"
```

- Replace `your_username` with your chosen username (e.g., `gcpuser`).
- Press Enter twice to skip setting a passphrase unless you prefer one.

This creates two key files in your local `.ssh` directory:

- `gcp_filezilla` (Private Key — used by FileZilla)
- `gcp_filezilla.pub` (Public Key — added to Google Cloud)

2 Add Public Key to Google Cloud

Register the key with your Compute Engine instance

1. Open and copy the entire text inside `gcp_filezilla.pub` using a text editor.
2. Go to Google Cloud Console > VM instances.
3. Click your VM instance name and click **Edit** at the top bar.
4. Scroll down to **SSH Keys**, click **Add Item**, and paste the copied public key.
5. Click **Save** at the bottom of the page.

3 Import Private Key into FileZilla

Configure FileZilla settings

1. Open FileZilla.
2. Go to **Edit > Settings...** (macOS: **FileZilla > Settings...**).
3. Select **SFTP** under the *Connection* category in the left sidebar.
4. Click **Add key file...** and navigate to your private key file (`~/.ssh/gcp_filezilla`).
5. Click **OK** to close settings.

*Note: If FileZilla asks to convert your key to PPK format (common on Windows), click **Yes** and save the converted file.*

4 Connect via Site Manager

Establish SFTP connection

1. In FileZilla, go to **File > Site Manager** and click **New site**.
2. Set the following properties:
    - **Protocol:** `SFTP - SSH File Transfer Protocol`
    - **Host:** *Your VM's External IP Address*
    - **Port:** `22`

- **Logon Type:** `Key file` or `Interactive`
- **User:** `your_username` (the exact username used in Step 1)

3. Click **Connect**.

Verification

Once connected, the right panel of FileZilla will list your remote VM's home directory (e.g., `/home/your_username`). You can test the connection by dragging a small file from your local machine (left pane) into the remote directory (right pane).
